

Does Populism Reduce Path Dependence in Public Policy?

Introduction

Path dependence in public policy refers to the process by which previous policy choices constrain future policy options through lock-in and feedback effects. Populism, characterised by anti-elitism and anti-establishment principles, may interfere with these feedback mechanisms. As populism becomes increasingly prevalent globally, it is important to understand its influence on policy development.

The research question is decomposed to address populism in opposition, entering government, and established in government.

I argue that populism does not reduce path dependence in opposition. The limited extent of oppositional influence manifests largely in scrutiny of the government party's proposals. The adversarial mandate of populist parties may entrench path dependency in this case, as larger policy reform is blocked or watered down. While oppositional populist ideas occasionally generate policy reform, they are incorporated into the wider government agenda, and path dependence is not reduced.

The transition of a populist party from opposition to government is more contextual. In cases where a majority government is achieved and executive power is concentrated, I argue that populism can generate policy discontinuities. However, these breaks do not constitute a sustained reduction in path dependence. The newly instituted reforms require institutions to implement, and the process of path dependence is reproduced. In cases where populist parties comprise part of a coalition government, or where democratic institutions are strong, the transition to government necessitates moderation of the party's campaign promises. The party is forced to work within existing institutions to implement incremental change, thereby maintaining path dependence.

Once established in government, I argue that populist parties do not decrease path dependence. The effort to maintain their appeal as anti-institutional reduces their ability to legislate, and their flexibility is gradually reduced through fiscal realities and the path dependence created by their early reforms.

Mechanisms of Path Dependence

Understanding the mechanisms of path dependence is necessary to identify where populism might be disruptive. Modern theories of path dependence developed from historical institutionalism in the late 1980s (Béland & Schlager, 2019). Policies generate bureaucracies, legal rules, administrative routines, and specialist expertise that generate institutional entrenchment. Reversal may become costly and difficult as a result. Pierson (1993) summarises why institutional development can lead to path dependency: "Policies may create incentives that encourage the emergence of elaborate social and economic networks, greatly increasing the cost of adopting once-possible alternatives and inhibiting exit from a current policy path".

Interests also generate self-reinforcing policy. Beneficiaries of policy have an incentive to support its continuity and expansion. Protected industries often exhibit this behaviour. In the European Union, for example, the agriculture industry lobbies strongly to protect the Common Agricultural Policy, blocking major reforms such as the Mercosur trade agreement (Kay, 2003).

The construction of target populations is another mechanism through which existing policies may be reinforced or undermined. Policy classifies groups as deserving or undeserving. This shapes public attitudes and participation, which can reinforce or undermine programmes. Closely related to this is the thermostatic model of Wlezien (1995), which asserts that public preferences respond to perceived over- or under-supply of policy.

A reduction in path dependence implies a sustained weakening of the mechanisms outlined above. Importantly, this is distinct from the concept of a 'critical juncture', or a break of path dependence, which refers to a discontinuity from the existing policy trajectory (Collier & Collier, 1991). Policy discontinuities may occur without sustainably weakening the underlying mechanisms of path dependence. Path dependence may be redirected through new institutions or the layering of existing institutions.

Evidence that populism's approach to institutions, interests, and ideas may disrupt the mechanisms of path dependence is now explored further.

Populist Path Breaking

The concept of populism is widely contested, and definitions vary along ideational, political, and cultural lines (Rovira Kaltwasser et al., 2017). Cas Mudde's widely cited definition is adopted here, referring to populism as "An ideology that considers society to be ultimately separated into two homogeneous and antagonistic groups, 'the pure people' versus 'the corrupt elite', and which argues that politics should be an expression of the *volonté générale* (general will) of the people" (Mudde, 2004).

This definition implies a fundamental antagonism between 'the people' and 'the corrupt elite'. While populist parties vary widely across the political spectrum, their rhetoric reflects this thin-centred ideology. Classifying parties as populist often relies on sentiment analysis to identify this antagonism. Populist rhetoric creates a clear 'us' and 'them' narrative, mobilising support through negative framing. Christo Pretorius (2024) employed this technique to classify Ireland's Sinn Féin as populist, and an example is included here for illustration: "EU banking policy, which is driven by unelected officials, favours banks and corporate elites at the expense of ordinary people."

A notable aspect of this statement, and a hallmark of populist rhetoric more generally, is its simplicity. The simplicity of populist messaging is a tool used to bolster political participation, with potential consequences for policy formation and path dependency.

Research has argued that depoliticisation of society has occurred as politics becomes increasingly technical, with policy justification beyond the comprehension of an average citizen (Fischer, 1990). Drawing on the Punctuated Equilibrium Theory of

policy formation developed by Baumgartner and Jones (1991), increased political participation can break down closed technocratic policymaking groups, widening the scope of consideration by creating new target populations. In turn, this can precipitate more radical policy change. Populist messaging disrupts technocracy through effective crisis mobilisation, engaging citizens otherwise disenfranchised from the policymaking process. This may serve to reduce path dependence.

The United Kingdom's Brexit referendum of June 2016 is an example of populist influence in opposition. The Conservative Party held a government majority at the time of the referendum and would not typically be classified as populist. However, their 2015 election manifesto had promised the Brexit referendum, a strategic concession to counter the rising popularity of the populist UK Independence Party (Hayton, 2018). Populist campaigners presented Brexit as an opportunity to disengage from a perceived corrupt EU elite and clamp down on immigration, creating the characteristic 'us' and 'them' narrative. Brexit illustrates that oppositional populism can at least generate conditions for policy discontinuity. Withdrawal from the European Union dismantled a significant institutional influence on the United Kingdom, potentially reducing path dependence. Developments since Brexit are discussed later to determine whether the case study illustrates a sustained reduction of path dependence.

Populist parties entering government are often not beholden to the entrenched interest coalitions that major non-populist parties are (Heinisch, 2003). Additionally, the thin-centred ideology of populism can create programmatic looseness, increasing the party's flexibility in adapting to political trends once in government. These factors combine to create a path-breaking opportunity as the populist party enters government.

A relevant case study supporting this position is Italy's Five Star party. Stemming from the Eurozone crisis, Five Star mobilised its supporters on the basis of distrust of the established government. Their success in the 2018 elections enabled them to form a coalition government with Lega, another populist party. The government quickly introduced Citizens' Income in early 2019, significantly reforming and expanding Italy's welfare system. Welfare reform is traditionally a domain of policy 'stickiness', with beneficiaries generating strong feedback effects. This case study is also returned to later to analyse whether it constitutes a sustained reduction in path dependence.

Once established in government, populist parties must continue to challenge existing institutions in order to continually prove their anti-establishment status. Where the populist party has a government majority or existing institutions are weak, this is often pursued through rule changes that concentrate the party's decision-making power (Urbinati, 2019). The Hungarian government of Viktor Orbán took this approach, revising the country's constitution, removing electoral districts, and reducing the number of government MPs. A similar strategy has characterised Donald Trump's presidency in the United States, and an increasingly populist Republican Party (Crothers, 2025). Trump has increased the use of executive orders and Judicial appointments and instituted federal hiring freezes. Concentration of power may

increase the government's responsiveness, thereby decreasing path dependency (Finnegan, 2022).

The body of evidence supports theoretical grounding for the assertion that populism reduces path dependence, as evidenced by the case studies of Brexit, Five Star, Viktor Orbán, and Donald Trump. However, this evidence has not fully clarified the distinction between reduced path dependence and isolated discontinuities. Research suggesting that populism does not reduce path dependence is explored next.

Populism as reproducing dependence

The antagonistic nature of populism is intrinsically oppositional. Louwerse and Otjes (2018) studied the behaviour of populist parties in opposition, focusing on the Netherlands, a typical consensus democracy. They found that populist parties were less likely to engage in policy-making behaviour while in opposition, instead focusing on scrutinising existing policy. In this scenario, it is unlikely that reforms would measurably reduce path dependence and may entrench it further by creating a roadblock to substantial reform.

The strength of oppositional influence is an important factor accounting for differences between the Netherlands and the earlier case study of Brexit. The Westminster system creates stronger oppositional agenda-setting influence, enabling oppositional populist parties to push for the Brexit referendum. However, Brexit did not generate a lasting reduction in path dependence. The fiscal reality of an EU exit became increasingly apparent in the years following the referendum, and subsequent governments have sought to repair relations with the Union. Brexit can therefore be classified as a policy discontinuity, rather than a sustained reduction in path dependence.

Populist governments are covered more widely in the literature than oppositional research. Research from Böhmelt and Ezrow (2023) found that the anti-elitism and the antagonistic framing of populist election campaigns undermine their ability to implement laws once in government. Their argument relies on the fact that once in government, populist parties must confront trade-offs between maintaining their anti-elite supporter base and addressing problems effectively. Focusing on immigration policy, central to many populist campaign platforms, they find empirical evidence to support their claim in 14 democratic states. Additionally, research from Adams et al. (2022) found that populist government policies are rejected by foreign political parties, increasing the difficulty of delivering on campaign promises with international ramifications.

While earlier examples illustrated that populist parties can certainly generate policy discontinuities when elected to government, the claim that these reforms reduce path dependency is weak. Remaining with the example of immigration policy, it is difficult to see how a populist party might deliver substantial policy reform without significant state-building. Immigration control requires the development of complex institutions to support border protection, screening, etc. It is therefore likely that populist governments will reproduce path dependency through state-building once in government.

Heinisch (2003) noted three structural weaknesses that undermine the populist government's ability to deliver sustained reform once established in government. The first point concerns the thin-centred ideology of populist parties, leading to instability within the party and an emphasis on personalities over institutions. Also related to this is a difficulty in creating a coherent programmatic agenda that achieves broad support across the disparate constituencies of such parties. Finally, a lack of experience affects the party's ability to deliver policy, particularly when in coalition. In this case, the populist party must moderate its stance to collaborate effectively, creating a 'filtration effect' that undermines its ability to effect sustained radical change. Some scholars take this further, asserting that populism is episodic rather than a durable form of government (Taggart, 2002).

Studying the mechanisms by which populist governments retain power, Devinney and Hartwell (2020) note a more general constraint on populist path breaking: "Normal democratic processes, especially in a parliamentary democracy, do not always lend themselves to populist ideas seeing the light of day - even if these ideas are popular - unless they are able to work initially within the institutional structure that exists". Once in government, populist parties inherit law-making institutions and fiscal constraints, undermining their ability to break from existing path-dependent policy. Instead, the populist government may be forced to layer their reforms on existing institutions, intensifying path dependency.

Rafael Correa's 2006 presidential election in Ecuador is an example of this. Correa's left populist Alianza PAIS upheld its election promise of abandoning orthodox neoliberalism, a marked discontinuity from existing policy¹. Alianza PAIS went on to consolidate power through public sector state-building, improving infrastructure, tax systems, and financial-sector regulation. The case study illustrates that while populist governments may introduce wide reforms and structural breaks from existing policy, the process of building new policy is likely to reproduce path dependency.

Institutional resilience also helps in understanding the cases of Viktor Orbán and Donald Trump. The strategies Trump employed to concentrate power have been constrained by significant institutional resistance. For example, courts reversed many of the 'Liberation Day' tariffs after ruling that Trump had exceeded the emergency powers used to impose them. Trump's programmatic flexibility has also been increasingly constrained by persistent inflation, which is likely to influence midterm election outcomes. As a result, path dependence has not been measurably reduced. The case of Viktor Orbán is somewhat different. Weaker democratic institutions gave Orbán greater power. Rather than reducing institutional constraints, Orbán constructed new self-reinforcing institutions to retain power through constitutional changes and redrawing of electoral districts. In this case, path dependence was intensified.

¹ An important contextual factor here is the decade of political instability prior to Correa's election, creating an environment more susceptible to radical reform. This is returned to in the limitations section of the essay.

Evaluation

The thin-centred ideology of populist parties challenges the mechanisms of path dependence while simultaneously undermining their ability to implement reforms. Resolving this tension is necessary to evaluate whether populism reduces path dependence.

It is evident from the analysis that populism challenges the mechanisms of path dependence in principle. Populism mobilises a disparate supporter base, breaking down closed policymaking groups and opening the door to more radical reform. Emerging populist parties are often beholden to fewer interest coalitions, widening the set of feasible policy options. Once in government, a willingness to concentrate executive power increases policy responsiveness. The claim that populism reduces path dependence, therefore, has strong theoretical grounding.

Temporal considerations as a populist party moves from opposition to government test this theoretical view. Limited power in opposition and an intrinsically antagonistic stance mutes the populist party's impact on policy outcomes and, by extension, on path dependency. The established governing parties largely have the power to counter or mitigate populist priorities as they see fit, incorporating them into their own agenda. The case study of Brexit illustrated that although populist ideas in opposition can sometimes generate policy reform, a reduction in path dependency cannot be sustained without executive power.

Entering government opens the door to more radical change, and the effect on path dependency becomes dependent on the strength of existing institutions and whether a majority is obtained. Where executive power is concentrated, populist parties may generate policy discontinuities, but once again, the temporary reduction in path dependence is unsustainable. The party must build institutions to implement its early policy reforms, and the process of path dependence resumes. The reforms implemented by Five Star in Italy illustrate this point. Examining this issue, Nesti & Graziano (2025) found that Citizens' Income was layered onto the National Social Security Institute, the existing social security bureaucracy it was meant to replace. Therefore, the reform has intensified institutional lock-in and path dependence.

As newcomer status fades, it becomes more challenging for populist parties to implement policy while maintaining their anti-institutional stance. The tension driven by this thin-centred ideology of populism manifests in programmatic instability. An under-supply of policy may shape a negative opinion of the government, as the thermostatic model suggests, thereby pressuring them to engage constructively in policymaking. Additionally, structural weaknesses in populist parties emerge from their thin-centred ideology, with fiscal, legal, and institutional constraints moderating change over time. The case studies of Orbán and Trump illustrated that path dependence is not reduced, irrespective of whether existing institutional resilience is strong.

Conclusion and Limitations

On balance, the research suggests populist parties and powerful populist ideas can generate isolated breaks of path dependence. However, the research showed that

although populism may disrupt path dependence, it does not reduce it. Any departure from an existing policy path must be sustained through new path dependence.

Additionally, populist parties face structural weaknesses that hinder sustained policy reform in government. Where power is concentrated, populist governments create new institutions that intensify lock-in. In cases where power is moderated through coalition or stronger institutions, the government must layer reforms on existing institutions, thereby continuing path dependence.

Populism comes in many forms, and while this essay sought to remain general in its approach, it focused on representative democracies that contain a variety of political factions. States with concentrated power or system-wide populism were not considered in depth and may exhibit different dynamics. A broader consideration of the wide varieties of populism would be useful for further research.

The rise of populism often coincides with broader socio-economic unrest, as illustrated by Ecuador's Alianza PAIS. A break from path dependence may occur in these cases, irrespective of whether a populist party comes to power. Although more specific than this essay's aims, a counterfactual study of populism in the context of global events would further enrich the research.

Finally, measuring path dependence requires policy observation over long periods of time. The case study of Donald Trump's presidency is not yet complete, and the inferential strength is therefore limited. Longitudinal studies of historical populist governments would add value to the research.

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